

Psychological Safety

A shared belief that the team is safe for interpersonal risk-taking

GLOSSARY 02 - SHEET 2 / 8

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Psychological safety is a shared belief held by members of a team that the team is safe for interpersonal risk-taking: that speaking up with a question, a concern, a mistake or a dissenting view will not lead to embarrassment, rejection or punishment. It is a property of the group climate rather than of individual personality, and it is distinct from trust, which concerns a dyad, and from cohesion, which can suppress dissent (Edmondson, 1999).

WHO DEFINED IT ORIGINALLY

Amy C. Edmondson defined and operationalised the construct at Harvard Business School in a 1999 study of 51 work teams in a manufacturing company, published in *Administrative Science Quarterly*. The antecedents are Schein and Bennis's (1965) work on organisational change and Kahn's (1990) study of personal engagement at work.

WHY THIS DEFINITION WAS DEVELOPED

Edmondson had found that better hospital units reported more medication errors, not fewer. Rather than accepting the perverse conclusion, she inferred that reporting rates measured climate rather than error rates, and needed a construct that explained why some teams surface problems and others conceal them. The construct then explained a general organisational phenomenon: the systematic suppression of upward bad news.

FIGURE 1 - SAFETY AND STANDARDS ARE INDEPENDENT

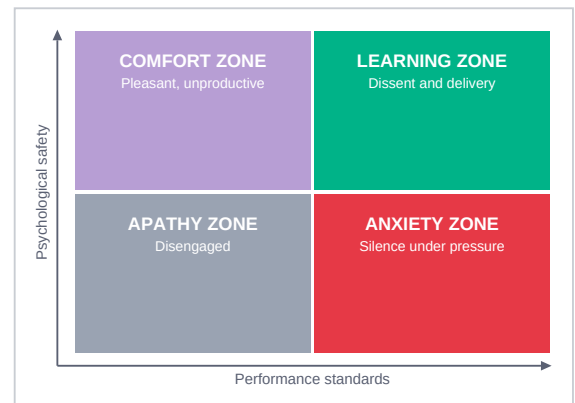


Figure 1. Psychological safety is not the absence of pressure. High standards without safety produce the anxiety zone, in which problems are known but unreported - the condition under which AI incidents accumulate silently (after Edmondson, 2018).

HOW IT IS USED

Measure the seven-item team-level scale, act on the result at team rather than individual level, and treat leader responses to bad news as the principal lever, since the climate is set by what happens the first time someone speaks up.

WHEN IT IS USED

Before an AI deployment where staff must report anomalies, after any incident that was known about before it occurred, at team formation, and whenever adoption metrics look uniformly positive.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Team leaders whose responses set the climate, human resources functions running the diagnostic, AI governance leads who depend on incident reporting, and executives interpreting unanimously favourable pilot reports.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO THE PREDECESSOR TOOL

Its predecessor as an explanation of team performance was cohesion, which the group dynamics literature had shown could reduce performance by discouraging dissent - Janis's (1972) groupthink. Psychological safety separates the willingness to disagree from the desire to belong, and it is measured at the level of the team rather than the individual. This made it possible to explain why high-performing teams report more errors, an outcome that cohesion-based models predicted backwards.

RELATED DEFINITIONS IN THIS COURSE

Organisational Culture - Unit 2

Decision Rights - Unit 2

Change Management - Unit 4

AI Governance - Unit 6

Human-in-the-Loop - Unit 2

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

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- Edmondson, A.C. (2018) *The Fearless Organization: Creating Psychological Safety in the Workplace for Learning, Innovation, and Growth*. Hoboken, NJ: John Wiley & Sons.
- Kahn, W.A. (1990) 'Psychological conditions of personal engagement and disengagement at work', *Academy of Management Journal*, 33(4), pp. 692-724.
- Newman, A., Donohue, R. and Eva, N. (2017) 'Psychological safety: a systematic review of the literature', *Human Resource Management Review*, 27(3), pp. 521-535.